

Iranians in L.A. see hints of hope with Cup

As U.S. restricts Iran team's entry, soccer fans seek unity among a divided diaspora.

By SUHAUNA HUSSAIN AND KEVIN BAXTER

Iran's World Cup team arrived in Tijuana last week bearing gold lapel pins on their jackets honoring the 168 victims, most of them schoolgirls, killed in a Feb. 28 U.S. missile strike on an elementary school in southern Iran at the outset of the war. The World Cup kicked off last week as that war in the Middle East continues, with Iran set to open play against New Zealand on Monday at SoFi Stadium in Inglewood. It's significant that the game will take place in the Los Angeles area, home to the largest Iranian population outside Iran.

Although Iran will play in the U.S., its players won't be allowed to stay here. The team moved its training base from Tucson to Tijuana last month because of visa hurdles and other travel restrictions levied by the Trump administration.

All of the 26 Iranian players were granted visas to play, but they will be forced to commute from Mexico. Several team officials had their visas denied at the last minute, and more than a dozen members of the Iranian delegation — mostly administrative, executive and technical staff — do not have permission to enter the U.S. The State Department said in a statement to ESPN that it issued "the necessary visas" and suggested the Iranian team could "abuse this system to sneak terrorists into the United States."

The Iranian Football Federation argues that the denial of visas to key staff constitutes political interference and violates the guarantees the U.S. made in 2018 to secure the rights to host the World Cup.

FIFA, for its part, says it has no authority over a host country's border enforcement and cannot override the U.S. But when Indonesian government officials said they would prohibit Israeli players and officials from entering for the U20 World Cup in 2023, FIFA made accommodations for the tournament to be held in Argentina, where Israel finished third.

The United States is the first host nation in World Cup history to be at war with a tournament qualifier. As a result, the mood in the Iranian community in Southern California, already tense and

[See World Cup, A7]

An EV startup runs out of juice

Monarch said its robots could revolutionize wine industry, but many vehicles had issues. **BUSINESS, A9**

Knicks win first title in 53 years

Led again by Jalen Brunson, New York rallies from another deficit to finish off San Antonio. **SPORTS, D1**

Hope takes root at the Broad

Locals flock to Yoko Ono's "Wish Trees" downtown to add their own words of support. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 82/61. **B6**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



7 85944 00200 5



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times



GUILLERMO ARIAS AFP/Getty Images

IRAN FANS cheer for the team as it departs Tijuana on Sunday. At top, Mehrzad Mozhdekanloo protests FIFA restrictions while holding the pre-1979 Iranian flag.

COVID-19 data suggest worrisome link to cancer

Pandemic enables researchers to deeply study long-term effects of viruses.

By CORINNE PURTILL

In early 2022, around the time the Omicron variant started driving a new surge in COVID-19 cases, researchers at James DeGregori's University of Colorado Anschutz lab noticed something unusual: When lab mice with dormant breast cancer cells were infected with either influenza or SARS-CoV-2, the animals were significantly more likely to develop aggressive

lung tumors.

What's true for a mouse isn't always true for a human. But when the team examined healthcare databases, they were surprised to find that something similar appeared to be going on in the human population.

Analysis of records from the U.K. Biobank showed that cancer survivors who contracted COVID in 2020 — when the virus was new and no vaccine was available — were significantly more likely to die of recurring cancer than patients who didn't get the virus, particularly within the year after their COVID infection.

Analysis of a separate U.S. breast cancer database found that breast cancer pa-

tients in remission who got COVID were significantly more likely to develop metastatic lung tumors than patients who did not contract the virus.

The University of Colorado researchers couldn't analyze influenza's effects as thoroughly — most flu infections don't make it into medical charts, as patients often ride out routine cases at home. They also weren't able to take into account whether the severity of a patient's COVID infection influenced the likelihood of a cancer recurrence. But COVID's novelty gave the team the data it needed to track the effects of viral inflammation on cancer recurrence. Their results

[See Virus, A8]

Locke High faces shutdown

LAUSD says, after 17 years, Watts charter is a failed experiment. Supporters fight on.

By HOWARD BLUME

A major education experiment lasting a generation is on the brink of a controversial ending as Los Angeles school district officials intend to shut down Alain LeRoy Locke College Preparatory Academy and take back the Watts campus from

its private operators.

Green Dot Public Schools, the charter group that has managed Locke for nearly two decades, is mounting a last-ditch appeal before the board of the county Office of Education, whose staff has also recommended closure.

At issue is whether about 1,000 students would fare better academically if Locke were run instead by the L.A. Unified School District, which concluded that Locke is "chronically underperforming." Based on that analysis, the school board in

March voted 4 to 3 to end the charter.

District officials point, essentially, to test scores that are lower than the state average, lower than other charters and lower than nearby district-operated "comparison" schools. The district says its charter evaluations are consistent and fair — based on rules set out by the state and district policy.

But Locke and its community supporters — including an array of elected officials and Tanya Ortiz

[See Charter, A7]



JAMES RANGER

AHEAD of the Mission Inn sale, William Keith's 1874 "California Alps" near the front desk is taken down.

Trump says U.S., Iran have a peace deal

Pact would reopen key strait as nuclear issues and other details are negotiated.

By ANA CEBALLOS AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Sunday that the United States and Iran have reached a framework agreement to end the war in the Middle East, a breakthrough in months of negotiations aimed at ending the conflict.

The deal, described by diplomats as a memorandum of understanding, commits Tehran to forgo the development or acquisition of nuclear weapons in exchange for helping reopen the Strait of Hormuz, and to the paced release of its assets frozen overseas, upon the signing of the deal Friday in Switzerland.

Trump said he has also authorized "the immediate removal of the United States Naval blockade" on Iranian

imports.

"Ships of the World, start your engines. Let the oil flow!" Trump wrote in a social media post Sunday evening. It was the president's 80th birthday.

The full details of the agreement have not been released. Many details — including how Tehran would give up, destroy or dilute its fissile material and whether Iran would continue treating the international strait as its sovereign waters — will continue to be negotiated in the coming days.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said Sunday that mediators are planning to hold a series of meetings this week to "lay the foundation for the technical talks and the official signing ceremony."

"We would like to thank the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran for their commitment to finding a diplomatic solution to the conflict," Sharif wrote in a post on X.

The Associated Press reported that negotiations [See Iran, A2]



JOHANNA ALARCON For The Times

MARIA Mero's husband, Gabriel Aladono Mero Delgado, was on the Fiorella, which went missing Jan. 20.

Attacks shrouded in mystery at sea

Ecuadorean fishermen tell of drones, a blue boat and abductors speaking English.

By PATRICK J. McDONNELL

MEXICO CITY — In March, a pair of Ecuadorean fishing boats in the Pacific burst into flames, forcing both crews to abandon ship. Months later, the incidents — which occurred well after the Trump administration launched its bombing campaign targeting alleged drug boats — have left more questions than answers.

All 36 crewmen survived, but they have recounted an astonishing story: The fishermen say that drones bombed their boats and that they were then taken at gunpoint as prisoners aboard U.S. military vessels. After some hours, the fishermen say, they were turned over to Salvadoran patrol boats, which took the crews to El

Salvador.

U.S. authorities deny any part in the puzzling series of events, which involved a pair of 35-ton fishing craft — not the sleek speedboats typically pictured in Department of Defense videos of maritime strikes.

Last week, two Democratic congressmen wrote to Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, Secretary of State Marco Rubio and other high-ranking Trump administration officials demanding "a full accounting" about the two boats and a third Ecuadorean fishing vessel that went down in January.

"These incidents have resulted in eight persons still missing or unaccounted for, credible survivor accounts of arbitrary or unlawful detention, abuse, and extrajudicial use of force by U.S. personnel," wrote Reps. Joaquin Castro (D-Texas) and Bill Keating (D-Mass.).

In an interview, Keating said: "Somebody did this, and we're in the region, we have eyes everywhere."

[See Boats, A3]

Locals see red in removal of art at Riverside's historic Mission Inn

By CHRISTOPHER REYNOLDS

In less than a month, Riverside's Mission Inn has gained a new owner, lost two prized pieces of art and sparked a heated debate over the line between private property and community history.

The stage for this controversy was set in early May, when hotel owner Kelly Roberts decided to sell the Mission Inn to the Yuhaaviatam

of San Manuel Nation, the tribe that owns the Yaa-mava' Resort & Casino in Highland and the Palms Casino Resort in Las Vegas.

But it wasn't the sale (for an undisclosed amount) that started removals.

It was Roberts' removal of two beloved paintings from the hotel before the sale closed.

One is an alpine landscape called "California Alps" (1874) by William Keith, which measures roughly 6 feet by 8 feet and

was displayed in the lobby near the front desk. The other painting, "Charge Up San Juan Hill" (circa 1900) by Vasily Vereshchagin, was displayed on a wall of the steakhouse near the lobby. Both paintings had been a part of the hotel for more than a century.

"It was like a slow-motion version of the Louvre Museum heist, pulled off on a sunny day in Riverside in view of guests, staff and visitors," wrote David Allen of [See Art, A10]